

CMS Audience Intelligence & Evidence Base — Track A8

AI Changes the Market | Draft for review | September 14, 2026

Research document; full Markdown source accompanies this PDF. Charts below use the report's cited source data.

Figure 1 — Selected AI adoption signals

Signal	%
Organizations using genAI in ≥ 1 function	71
SMBs using AI	38
SMBs using AI for marketing/social	28
B2B buyers using GenAI in purchase	45

Figure 2 — Upwork 2026 value split

Metric	YoY
GenAI + creative production contract starts	+90%
GenAI + creative production earnings/contract	−13%
AI execution-task earnings	−28%
AI-augmented professional-services volume	+72%
AI-augmented professional-services earnings	+22%
Complex AI work earnings	+45%

Figure 3 — AI use across B2B buying journey

Stage	%
Early research	72
Compare vendors	62
Narrow shortlist	48
Final decision	45

Core findings

- AI adoption is becoming normal operating practice; AI literacy is moving toward table stakes.
- AI materially compresses the labor required for defined knowledge and production tasks.
- Upwork 2026 shows a split: lower-complexity AI execution is scaling while its unit economics weaken; complex AI-augmented

- AI introduces an authenticity problem; perceived AI authorship can reduce loyalty and word of mouth in emotional marketing.
- Agency AI adoption is widespread, but operational maturity is uneven.
- Therefore, the premium shifts toward context, judgment, specialization, accountability, and business outcomes rather than production volume.

CMS Audience Strategy Data

- Evidence-derived objection: "Why pay for posts when AI can create them?"
- Evidence-derived objection: "Can't my VA use ChatGPT for this?"
- Evidence-derived objection: "Why hire an agency if my team can do more in-house?"
- Evidence-derived objection: "How do I know this is not just AI-generated content?"
- Evidence-derived objection: "Why trust your recommendation over what ChatGPT says?"
- Strategic implication: CMS should make diagnosis, strategic interpretation, specialized context, human accountability, and inspectable proof visible.
- AI should be an operating capability for CMS, not the core brand differentiator.

What A8 adds beyond A6

- A6 established that AI is widening the strategy/execution gap. A8 explains the mechanism: more production capacity → less execution scarcity → more internal/low-cost alternatives → higher agency selectivity → greater importance of public evidence and human validation → higher relative value for judgment and accountability.

Source note

The full Markdown version contains the complete findings, confidence methodology, limitations, audience tables, and 20-source bibliography. See the accompanying file.